Life Cycles

By Joshua Sands

INTRODUCTION

Growth occurs in cycles. The cycle of childhood, of puberty, of adulthood, of parenthood, of midlife, of retirement, of death. The trick to marriage is to find someone whose cycle matches your own. When two people's life cycles are in sync, they are able to maintain a healthy relationship. When the cycles are out of sync, the relationship is doomed to cycle into failure. A relationship that exemplifies the latter is put on display in "Life Cycles" by Joshua Sands.

JASON: Honey, I'm home! (A beat) Honey, I'm home! (Another beat) What's for dinner? Well, whatever it is, it smells -

KARA: Jason? Jason is that you?

JASON: Yes, Kara. I'm finally home.

KARA: Jason, it's been three years! Where have you - I mean, what have you - (a beat) Jason, it's so good to see you!

JASON: You're a sight for sore eyes.

KARA: I've missed you terribly.

JASON: I know. I'm sorry.

KARA: Where did you go? Why haven't you called? Jason - what happened?

JASON: I drove around for a while. Tried A.A. Gave up on that. Dried out in a clinic but let's not talk about that right now. Where's my little Allison?

KARA: No, Jason. Let's *do* talk about that now.

JASON: Kara, let's not deal with the past. Only the present. You and me. And little Allison.

KARA: She's not so little anymore. She starts kindergarten in the fall.

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JASON: WOW - time flies...

KARA: For you, maybe.

(to the audience)

KARA: See, Jason was the love of my life. Met in high school. Went to the same college. Married almost the same time we got our diplomas. We had two good years. You know, he drank a little, but don't we all? But I didn't see it as a problem. Then one night he gets a little weird on me:

JASON: Kara, the system's really quite easy.

KARA: Jason, I-

JASON: The receipts go in the blue folder, the income tax forms in the red, stocks in the yellow. Some of the folders you won't need for months. You know, it all goes in cycles.

KARA: What about the horny green folder?

JASON: Miscellaneous forms - remember?

KARA: Jason - I just don't see -

JASON: I just thought you should know a little bit more about the finances.

KARA: But I always have you take care of that.

JASON: Well sure, but you never know.

KARA: Never know what?

JASON: You just never know.

KARA: And those were the last four words I heard him say. He disappeared the next day. Boss called. He'd emptied his desk. Six months later I get a message on the machine:

JASON: Hey, honey damn - I'm talkin' to my wife - wait your turn! I just wanted to

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tell you that I'm in Detroit drying out. No problem. Just wait for me, OK? OK, bye ...

KARA: So, I waited. Six months. A year. Mom helped take care of the baby. I worked. But soon I gave up. Divorced him via federal express. Soon enough, he became a memory. Some distant dream of a life long since past, back when I believed in fairy tales. But now, he's standing here telling me:

JASON: Kara, let's start over. Let's do it right this time. No alcohol. No secrets. No lies.

KARA: I never lied to you.

JASON: OK, so I'll start over. You just stay the same. You are already perfect that way.

KARA: Jason, do you have any idea what these years have been like? Do you?

JASON: I know it's been rough, but -

KARA: I'm not the same person anymore. I'm not. I've grown up. I stay home on Saturday nights. I drink wine coolers and get tipsy. I even see signs that I'm becoming my mother. I'm not the person you married.

JASON: But you could be. We could be. Give me that chance. I want to be a good husband. And a good father. Give me that chance.

KARA: Jason-

JASON: We did have some good times, didn't we?

KARA: Well sure -

JASON: It wasn't all bad ...

KARA: Well, not before the -

JASON: Then let's try it. One date. We'll go back to Musselman's bistro. We'll

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order that special -

KARA: The bistro closed two years ago.

JASON: We'll get good food. I promise. Look, I know this is a lot coming at you all at once, but -

KARA: OK. One date. One date. That's all.

JASON: I'll put on a monkey suit if you like ...

KARA: Just pick me up at 6:00 tomorrow. OK?

JASON: Sure, I know you don't like to wait.

KARA: Actually, I've gotten better at it.

(the date)

JASON: SO, then, this guy starts saying "Oh yeah? You and what army? And then my military buddies stand up and I say "This Army". Now they were Marines, but the guy didn't know that ... he about wet his pants. You know I felt like the Fonz ... just snap my fingers and ... "eeeyyy".

KARA: (Laughing) Wow - you certainly have some stories to tell!

JASON: Always did.

KARA: Remember that one time you got up to go to the bathroom in the middle of the night but walked into the wrong room. I caught you, pants down, sitting on the trash can!

JASON: (Laughing) Yeah, that trash can and I bonded, didn't we?

KARA: I'd say so.

JASON: Kara, it's so good to see you.

KARA: I've missed you, too.

JASON: You've made me laugh for the first time in I don't know how long.

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KARA: Trust me - I thought I'd forgotten how.

JASON: Ever since the first day, Junior year of high school. I looked at you and said "That babe will be mine."

KARA: You called me a babe?

JASON: It was before I got Pc. You know - back when the world had a sense of humor.

KARA: Sure.

JASON: (A beat) I know I owe you a lot. I can't begin to say how much.

KARA: Jason, please don't ...

JASON: Your eyes sparkle and light up the room. I want that sparkle back.

KARA: Jason - just dinner ... remember?

JASON: I know I'm rushing, but it feels so right. Kara, will you do me the honor of being my wife?

KARA: (A long beat) Wh-What?

JASON: We could do it all over again. We'll do the wedding with the same yellow roses. Allison could be the flower girl. We could go to Monaco for the honeymoon. We could do it all over -

KARA: Jason, wait.

JASON: What?

KARA: Just wait.

JASON: One word is all I'm asking for and I'll take it from there. Just say yes.

KARA: Jason, you LEFT me! You left without a word. One call in three years. No presents for Allison's birthday or Christmas. Nothing. Did you know she got picked on at pre-school? You know why? Because of you! Everyone knew

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the story.

JASON: Kara, I can't fix that now. I can only--

KARA: Do you know what it's like to go to the supermarket and hear them whispering? Either they thought it was my fault or I was pitied. Do you know how humiliating that was for me? DO YOU?

JASON: Honey, I'm so sorry. I had no clue-

KARA: That's right. You had no fucking clue! So let's get off this marriage idea for one second and *you* answer *me* a question. Why'd you go?

JASON: I was drunk.

KARA: Why'd you go?

JASON: Kara, I was just in a bad state of mind

KARA: Why the hell did you go???

JASON: (breaking down) I don't know. I just don't know. I guess I just wanted to be like that magician who could pull out the tablecloth and leave all the table-settings in place. Take me out. Leave you and Allison in place.

KARA: You know it doesn't work that way, I spent three years waiting for you. I love you, Jason, but I can't do it again.

JASON: You wouldn't have to.

KARA: The answer is no. I won't marry you.

JASON: Is that "No, not now" or "No not ever?"

KARA: Jason, it's just plain no.

(to the audience)

KARA: So now a different night haunts me. It's no longer the folders and the finances. It's the magician and the tablecloth. Three months later he

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called and left a drunken message on the answering machine. Six months later - rehab. And the cycle had begun all over again. But see, if it really is a cycle, then I relive the moment that he came back, wondering if it will happen again:

JASON: Honey, I'm home! (A beat) Honey, I'm home! (Another beat) What's for dinner? Well, whatever it is, it smells –

KARA: Jason? Jason is that you?

JASON: Yes, Kara. I'm finally home.

KARA: Only this time I take the offer. I take the ring. He moves back in. Allison has a father. And the cycle starts all over again.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Joshua Sands
Book: Turning Points
Publisher: Tichenor Publishing
ISBN: 0742117014
Date: 2001

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